

The Ministry of Defence (abbreviated as MoD; ISO: Rakṣā Mantrālaya) is charged with coordinating and supervising all agencies and functions of the government relating directly to national security and the Indian Armed Forces.

The President of India is the ceremonial commander-in-chief of the armed forces of the country. The Ministry of Defence provides a policy framework and resources to the armed forces to discharge their responsibility in the context of the country's defence. The Indian Armed Forces (including the Indian Army, the Indian Air Force, the Indian Navy) and the Indian Coast Guard under the Ministry of Defence are primarily responsible for ensuring the territorial integrity of India.

As per Statista, MoD is the largest employer in the world with 30.5–31 lakh (3.05–3.1 million) employees.

At present, the new creation of National Defence University, for the training of military officials and concerned civilian officials, will be administered and overseen by the Ministry. The Ministry organises and runs Republic Day celebrations and parade every year in January at Rajpath, hosting a chief guest. The Ministry has the largest budget among the federal departments of India and currently stands third in military expenditure in the world, among countries of the world.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Defence, consisting of elected members from both the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha, is tasked with this ministry's legislative oversight.

History

A Military Department was created in the Supreme Government of the English East India Company at Calcutta in the year 1776, having the main function to sift and record orders relating to the Army issued by various Departments of the Government of East India Company. The Military Department initially functioned as a branch of the Public Department and maintained a list of Army personnel.

With the Charter Act 1833, the Secretariat of the Government of the East India Company was reorganised into four departments, each headed by a secretary to the Government. The armies in the presidencies of Bengal, Bombay, and Madras functioned as the respective presidency armies until April 1895, when the presidency armies were unified into a single Indian Army. For administrative convenience, it was divided into four commands: Punjab (including the North West Frontier), Bengal (including Burma), Madras and Bombay (including Sindh, Quetta and Aden).

The supreme authority over the Indian Army was vested in the Governor General-in-Council, subject to the control of the Crown, which was exercised by the Secretary of State for India. Two members of the council were responsible for military affairs. One was the Military Member, who supervised all administrative and financial matters. The other was the commander-in-chief, who was responsible for all operational matters. The Military Department was abolished in March 1906 and replaced by two separate departments: the Army and the Military Supply departments. In April 1909, the Military Supply Department was abolished, and the Army Department took over its functions. The Army Department was redesignated as the Defence Department in January 1938. The Department of Defence became the Ministry of Defence under a cabinet minister in August 1947.

Before Partition of India, in 1946, Iskander Mirza was elevated as Joint Secretary to the Government of India at the Ministry of Defence in New Delhi, who later went onto become 1st President of Pakistan. Notable officers included - Philip Mason, Ambrose Dundas, Richard Tottenham, Charles Ogilvie.

Before the partition of the Indian subcontinent, there was a unified defense system for the entire subcontinent. However, with the creation of two separate nations, the Ministry of Defence in New Delhi was split, and a new Ministry of Defence (Pakistan) was created in Pakistan. The separation of the defense ministries was part of the larger administrative and bureaucratic split that saw Indian military assets, personnel, and infrastructure divided

between the two nations.

Role

The responsibility for national defence "rests with the Cabinet, which is discharged through the Ministry of Defence, which provides the policy framework and wherewithal to the Armed Forces to discharge their responsibilities in the context of the defence of the country. The Raksha Mantri (Defence Minister) is the head of the Ministry of Defence."

The Defence Ministry is responsible for "obtaining policy directions of the Government on all defence and security related matters" and communicating these directions to "Services Headquarters, Inter-Services Organisations, Production Establishments and Research and Development Organisations". The MoD works closely with the National Security Council, Ministry of External Affairs and the Ministry of Home Affairs.

Modern era: 20th and 21st century

The functions of MoD, which in 1947 were mainly logistic support to the armed forces, have undergone far-reaching changes. In November 1962, following the 1962 war, a Department of Defence Production was set up to deal with research, development, and production of defence equipment. In November 1965, the Department of Defence Supplies was created for planning and execution of schemes for the import substitution of requirements for defence purposes. These two Departments were later merged to form the Department of Defence Production and Supplies.

In 1980, the Department of Defence Research and Development was created. In January 2004, the Department of Defence Production and Supplies was renamed the Department of Defence Production. A Scientific Adviser to the Defence Minister was appointed to advise on scientific aspects of military equipment and the research and design of defence forces' equipment. The Department of Ex-Servicemen Welfare was created in 2004. Notable officers in recent history

in MOD include - T. N. Seshan, R. K. Singh, Hardeep Singh Puri.

Property portfolio

The Ministry of Defence is one of India's largest landowners, owning over 17.99 lakh acres of land across India, and the largest landowner among all ministries of the Government of India. This is managed by the Defence Estates Organisation under the Ministry of Defence.

Main Building

The current headquarters of the Ministry of Defence is in Secretariat Building, New Delhi. Under the Central Vista Redevelopment Project, the Ministry will be relocated into a Defence Enclave inside the Common Central Secretariat. The Defence Enclave will be housed within specific blocks of the Central Vista Secretariat, currently identified as CCS-6, CCS-7, and CCS-8.

Organisation

Departments

The Ministry of Defence consists of five departments: the Department of Defence (DoD), the Department of Military Affairs (DMA), the Department of Defence Production (DDP), the Department of Defence Research and Development (DRDO), and the Department of Ex-Servicemen Welfare (DESW). The Defence Secretary of India functions as head of the Department of Defence, and is additionally responsible for coordinating the activities of the departments in the ministry.

The principal functions of all the departments are as follows:

The Department of Defence, headed by the Defence Secretary, the department deals with the defence of India including defence policy, preparation for defence, acts conducive to prosecution of war, the Reserves of the Army, Navy and Air Force, Defence Accounts, Indian

Coast Guard, Border Roads Organisation, capital acquisitions for defence and various establishment matters. It is also responsible for the Institute for Defence Studies and Analysis, National Defence College and any other organisation within the Ministry of Defence whose remit is broader than military matters. It is also responsible for the Defence Budget, matters relating to the Parliament, defence cooperation with foreign countries, and coordination of all activities.

The Department of Military Affairs, is responsible for managing the armed forces of India, namely, the Army, the Navy, and the Air Force. It is also responsible for the Territorial Army. It is headed by the Chief of Defence Staff as its secretary. It deals with procurement exclusive to the Indian Armed Forces, except for capital acquisitions. It is designed to promote jointness among the military services of India. This department was approved on 24 December 2019, and the responsibilities notified by Cabinet Secretariat order on 30 December 2019.

The Department of Defence Production, headed by the Defence Production Secretary, the department was set up in November 1962 and is responsible for matters about defence production, planning and control of departmental production units of the Ordnance Factories Board, indigenisation of imported stores equipment and spares and has ownership over the following central public sector undertakings

The Department of Defence Research and Development is headed by the Defence Research and Development Secretary and ex-officio chairperson of Defence Research and Development Organisation. The department was formed in 1958, after the three-way merger of the Technical Development Establishment of the Indian Army, the Directorate of Technical Development and Production, and the Defence Science Organisation. The department is responsible for the Defence Research and Development Organisation.

The Department of Ex-servicemen Welfare (DESW) is headed by the Ex-Servicemen Welfare Secretary. The department was set up in 2004 to look after veteran affairs. The Directorate General of Resettlement, the Kendriya Sainik Board, and the Ex-Servicemen Contributory

Health Scheme come under the purview of DESW.

Military departments and services

Finance Division

The Finance Division of the Ministry of Defence is headed by the Financial Adviser (Defence Services). The financial advisor exercises financial control over proposals involving expenditure from the Defence Budget and is responsible for the internal audit and accounting of defence expenditure. In the latter tasks, the financial advisor is assisted by the Controller General of Defence Accounts.

Schools

Sainik Schools

Indian Army Public Schools

Institutes and Universities

Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses

Defence Institute of Advanced Technology

Defence Institute of Psychological Research

National Defence University

Aeronautical Development Agency

Inter-services organisations

Source:

Integrated Defence Staff

To ensure a high degree of synergy between the Armed forces, the Government has set up

the Integrated Defence Staff, headed by the Chief of Integrated Defence Staff as the chairman. It was created on 1 October 2001 based on the recommendations of the Group of Ministers which was set up in 2000 (post the Kargil War) to review India's defence management. It acts as the point organisation for integration of policy, doctrine, war-fighting and procurement by employing best management practices. The chairman of the Integrated Defence Staff is a 4-star General (or his equivalent in the Air Force or the Navy).

The first Chief of Defence Staff was General Bipin Rawat, who took over on 1 January 2020.

Chiefs of Staff Committee

"Chiefs of Staff are the authority for advising the Defence Minister and normally through him the Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs on all military matters which require ministerial consideration". The Integrated Defence Staff is "the principal arm and Secretariat to the Chiefs of Staff Committee".

Composition

The Chiefs of Staff Committee is composed of: (a) Chief of the Army Staff (COAS); (b) Chief of the Naval Staff (CNS); (c) Chief of the Air Staff (CAS); and (d) Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) (non-voting member). The Scientific Adviser to the Minister of Defence is invited to attend whenever needed.

The senior-most member of the COSC is appointed as its chairperson. General Bipin Rawat was the last head of COSC. The position of COSC has ceased to exist with the creation of Chief of Defence Staff. General Bipin Rawat was appointed the first Chief of Defence Staff in 2019. He died in a helicopter crash on 8 December 2021.

Organizational structure

Cabinet

MoD is headed by the Defence Minister of India, who is supported by one or more ministers of state.

Senior officials

There are about 400,000 defence civilians, under the MOD, including Ministry of Finance personnel attached to the MOD. In 2015–16, the Defence pension bill was ₹54,500 crore (equivalent to ₹780 billion or US\$8.1 billion in 2023) of which about 36 per cent was on account of defence civilians.[66]

Defence Secretary, other senior officials, and Scientific Adviser to Defence Minister

The ministers are supported by several civilian, scientific, and military advisers.

The Defence Secretary as head of the Department of Defence, is the senior most civil servant in the ministry and is responsible for coordinating the activities of the five departments in the ministry. His/her role is to ensure that the MoD operates effectively as a department of the government. Defence Secretary is assisted by additional secretaries and joint secretaries to Government of India posted in the ministry. The Defence Secretary, generally, is an officer from the Indian Administrative Service. Apart from the Defence Secretary, there are three other secretary-level posts in the Ministry of Defence.

The Scientific Adviser to the Defence Minister plays a key role in the formulation of research and development policies and in promoting self-reliance in Indian defence industries.

Chiefs of the tri-services and Defence Staff

In 1955, the title of Commander-in-Chief was abolished and the three service chiefs were designated as the Chief of the Army Staff, the Chief of the Naval Staff and the Chief of the Air Staff. The heads of the three services of Indian Armed Forces are:

Vice Chiefs of the tri-services and Defence Staff

Services

Civil Services under Ministry of Defence

Other services under Ministry of Defence

Armed Forces Medical Services

Initiatives

SRIJAN portal

The SRIJAN is a portal launched by the MoD to take up the products imported for indigenisation. According to the Ministry, it displays defence products that have been imported recently and will be tagged with the Defence Public sector undertakings, Ordnance Factory Board, and others to push for its domestic manufacturing for exports in the future.

Defence public sector undertakings and other bodies

The Ministry of Defence owns and oversees several Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs) that play a vital role in India's defence production ecosystem. These Defence Public Sector Undertakings (DPSUs) are tasked with the design, development, and manufacturing of defence equipment and technologies, including arms, ammunition, ships, aircraft, and electronics, to meet the strategic requirements of the Indian Armed Forces.

The DPSUs operate under the Department of Defence Production.

Indo-Russian Rifles Pvt. Ltd.

Defence Innovation Organisation

List of operations by the Ministry of Defence

The Ministry of Defence has overseen all major military actions involving the Indian Armed

Forces since independence. Under its authority, India has fought four full-scale wars—1947–48, 1965, 1971, and 1999—each involving coordinated tri-service operations.

Apart from full-scale wars, the MoD has directed or approved around five to six limited border conflicts, including standoffs with China at Nathu La, Sumdorong Chu, Doklam, and Galwan. It has also overseen two to three cross-border strikes, notably the 2016 surgical strikes and the 2019 Balakot air strike.

Counter-insurgency operations have been a continuous MoD-led effort, with more than ten long-term missions in regions like Jammu and Kashmir, Assam, and Manipur. India's participation in about five to six UN peacekeeping missions has also been managed by the MoD.

In addition, the MoD has led over ten humanitarian and disaster relief operations, both domestically and abroad, using military assets. While covert operations remain classified, many are believed to involve MoD-level oversight when military resources are deployed.

Collaboration and pacts

USA

India and the United States have signed a foundational agreement as defence partners. The following pacts are - General Security of Military Information Agreement (2002), Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement (2016), Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement (2018), Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement (2020), Indo-U.S. Defense Framework Agreement (2005), India-U.S. Defense Trade and Technology Initiative, Quadrilateral Security Dialogue.

In 2016, the United States designated India as a Major Defense Partner and was elevated to Strategic Trade Authorization tier 1 status.

United Kingdom

India and the United Kingdom have together signed the India-UK Defense Cooperation Agreement (2006), Joint Statement on Strengthening India-UK Strategic Partnership (2010). The United Kingdom, in February 2025, announced the formal launch of "Defence Partnership-India", or DP-I, a dedicated cell within the Ministry of Defence (United Kingdom) for deepening cooperation with India. The UK has also supported India's efforts to join the Nuclear Suppliers Group.

Israel

India and Israel have together signed the India-Israel Defense Cooperation Agreement (2003).

Australia

India and Australia have together signed the India-Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (2020), Cooperation in Defense and Security (2009).

Other countries

India has signed defense pacts and strategic partnerships with more than 18 countries, including Russia, France, Japan, Saudi Arabia, Brazil.

Related legislation

The legislation related to India's Ministry of Defence includes the foundational Acts for each service branch: the Army Act, 1950, the Navy Act, 1957, and the Air Force Act, 1950. The other key laws include the Indian Territorial Army Act, 1948, the National Cadet Corps Act, 1948, the Civil Defence Act, 1968, and the Defence of India Act, 1971, which was used during the Indo-Pak war. Modern policy-focused legislation includes the Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP) 2020, promoting indigenous production and self-reliance.

See also

Minister of Defence (India)

National Defence Academy (India)

National Defence College (India)

Defence Research and Development Organisation

Indian Naval Academy

Notes

References

External links

Official Website Ministry of Defence, India

Official Website of Department of Defence Production

Official Website of Defence Research and Development Organisation

Annual Report for the year 2016–17

Defence Directory of Important Web Links of MOD

Official Website of the Integrated Defence Staff

Sainik Samachar Armed Forces News